

were built at Tempelhof and Gatow to take the mounting flow of traffic. By September, in good weather the airlift was comfortably exceeding its minimum target. But as winter drew in, pilots found themselves flying through at best persistent low cloud and rain, and at worst fog, ice, and snow.

Under the intense pressure of the occasion, with the future of a city turning on the success or failure of the airlift, the normally unheroic business of air-traffic control, instrument flying, and logistical organization took on heroic status. Although the Soviets flew many harassment missions and often fired on the Allied transports, they actually missed their targets on purpose. However, maintaining the flights at intervals of between three and six minutes by day and night imposed heavy risks. In all, 54 Allied airmen lost their lives in the airlift, and limiting losses to that level required the utmost discipline from all those involved – from the airmen and air-traffic controllers to the ground crews who kept the transports faultlessly operational.



BLOCKADE LIFTED

A cheer is raised at the news in May 1949 that the Soviet blockade of Berlin has been lifted. The airlift continued until the supply situation had returned to normal in the following September.

communist North Korea invaded South Korea and a US-led coalition went in under the UN flag to take on the aggressors. The Chinese soon joined the war in

By February 1949 the Combined Airlift Task Force was shifting 8,000 tons of supplies a day. It was obvious to the Soviets that their ploy had failed, and they ended the land blockade in May. The airlift continued until September, by which time the transports had made around 277,000 flights.

The Berlin Airlift had only been over for 10 months when the next Cold War crisis erupted in Asia, as

support of North Korea and Soviet “volunteers” flew planes for the North Korean air force. The Korean conflict was hot war and no doubt about it, yet it shared with the Berlin Airlift the characteristic feature of aerial conflict in the Cold War period – the imposition of rules to prevent a full-scale war between the major powers. In Germany, the Soviets did not use their fighters or anti-aircraft capability against Allied transport aircraft; in Korea, the Americans not only did not use nuclear weapons but also banned their airmen from striking against airbases inside China, from which enemy fighters operated.

The Korean War

The first stage of American involvement in the war was a classic demonstration of the importance of air power on the modern battlefield. The North Korean advance on the ground was first stopped and then pushed back, partly through the devastating impact of attacks by bombers and fighter-bombers flying close air support and

GIANT GLOBEMASTER

USAF personnel and civilians unload flour from the cargo hold of a Douglas C-74 Globemaster at Gatow airfield, Berlin. The C-74 was the largest transport aircraft used in the Berlin Airlift.



POPULAR CARGO-CARRIER

Children standing on rubble in West Berlin wave to a Douglas C-47 in the early stages of the Berlin Airlift. The C-47s could not carry a sufficient weight of cargo to supply the city and were soon replaced as the key component of the airlift by the four-engine Douglas C-54 Skymasters.

